Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Jonah

Jonah 1:1

Jonah, son of Amittai, came from Gath-hepher. This town was on the border between the tribal areas of Naphtali and Zebulun. He served the northern kingdom of Israel during the reign of Jeroboam II, from 793 to 753 BC (see 2 Kings 14:25).

Jonah 1:1–2.10

Jonah first refused the Lord's command to warn Nineveh about the judgment it faced due to its wickedness.

Jonah 1:2

- By the time of Jonah, Nineveh already had a long history (see Genesis 10:12). It was an important city in the Assyrian Empire until it was destroyed in 612 BC (see Nahum 1–3). Nineveh's ruins are across the Tigris River from the modern city of Mosul, Iraq.
- great city: See study note on Jonah 3:3.

Jonah 1:3

- Jonah tried to run away from the Lord, but he could not succeed. No one can escape God (Psalm 139:7–10) or disobey his will without facing consequences (Deuteronomy 8:5). Jonah's hesitation to go to Nineveh is understandable. Assyria was an enemy of Israel known for its violence (Jonah 3:8; see also Nahum 3:1–4). Jonah did not want these non-Israelites to have the chance to repent and be saved (Jonah 4:2).
- Joppa was an important port city on the Mediterranean coast (2 Chronicles 2:16; Ezra 3:7); it is now a suburb of modern Tel Aviv.
- Tarshish might have been the port city of Tartessos in Spain, meaning Jonah tried to flee as far as possible in the opposite direction from Nineveh. Tarsus in Asia Minor is another possibility. Some believe Tarshish refers to the sea or any destination reachable by sea.

Jonah 1:4

God's control over nature is a key theme in the book of Jonah (see Jonah 1:4, 9, 13–16, 17; 2:3, 10; 4:6–7).

Jonah 1:5–6

God may have caused Jonah to keep sleeping to show that the sailors' gods could not help (Jonah 1:6).

Jonah 1:7–8

- God permitted the use of lots for certain purposes, such as making decisions when people sought his will (see Leviticus 16:8; Joshua 18:6; 1 Chronicles 26:12–16; Acts 1:26). However, divination in general, as it was practiced throughout the ancient world, displeased the Lord because it sought guidance apart from him (Deuteronomy 18:9–13).
- who is responsible for this calamity that is upon us: In the ancient Near East, people often believed that disasters or bad events happened because a god was angry. They assumed that someone had caused offense and needed to be identified.

Jonah 1:9

- a Hebrew: See also Genesis 41:12; Exodus 1:15; 2:11.
- Jonah worshiped the Lord, who, unlike the sailors' false gods, made and controlled the sea and land. Many believed different gods ruled specific areas and tasks. Calling God the God of the heavens likely showed this deity's superiority, as heaven is the highest realm. The Old Testament consistently states that the Lord is the one true God (see, for example, Deuteronomy 6:4), sometimes using language to show his superiority over false gods imagined by pagan peoples (see Psalm 95:3–5).

Jonah 1:12

Pick me up: Jonah's calmness in giving this direction is surprising. But he was willing to face death peacefully rather than give the hated Assyrians a chance to repent.

Jonah 1:13–14

the men rowed hard: They knew Jonah had angered the Lord, but they worried the Lord would be angrier if they killed his prophet.

Jonah 1:16

feared: God's power over the stormy sea led the sailors to worship. Although sacrifices and vows were part of Israelite worship (for example, Psalm 116:17–18), the sailors likely did not fully convert from worshiping false gods. They probably added Israel's God to their list. This situation is deeply ironic. Pagan sailors showed respect and honor toward the Lord, while the Lord's own prophet dishonored him. The prophet then seemed to sink into the sea and face death (compare study note on Jonah 2:8–9).

Jonah 1:17

- Some critics find it hard to believe that Jonah could survive inside a large fish. They challenge one of the book's main ideas, that God has complete control over nature. If God exists and created nature (Jonah 1:9, 16; see also Genesis 1:21), such a miracle is possible. The book treats the fish story as historical.
- The species of the fish is not specified, nor is it important for the story's meaning. Given God's power, the fish could have been specially created for this event. If God can perform miracles, Jonah's need for air and protection from digestion is not a problem (see Daniel 3:14–27). Some fish, like the whale shark, are large enough for this purpose, and similar events have happened in modern times.
- Jesus later mentioned Jonah's three days and nights in the fish to predict his own time in the grave (Matthew 12:39–41).
- The phrase appointed appears four times in the book, showing God's easy control over nature (Jonah 4:6, 7, 8).

Jonah 2:1–9

Jonah realized that the Lord had kindly saved him by sending the fish. He then created a prayer similar to a psalm. The prayer's careful structure follows the pattern of a personal song of thanks. This suggests Jonah may have written it after the event, as he remembered his feelings and worries.

Jonah 2:2

- Jonah's psalm-prayer begins by recalling an earlier, less polished but more fervent prayer (his cry for help when he was about to drown).
- From the belly of Sheol: Sheol was believed to be the place where the dead lived (see Isaiah 14:15; Ezekiel 31:15–17). The metaphor of Sheol as a belly is unique in the Old Testament. It pictures Jonah's rescue from Sheol through the belly of a fish.

Jonah 2:4

- As Jonah was about to drown, he called out for help, life, and God's renewed presence. It is ironic that Jonah mentioned God driving him away, as Jonah himself aimed to flee to Tarshish (Jonah 1:3).
- I will look once more: Jonah was either confident he would be rescued and worship again in the temple in Jerusalem, or he was calling to the Lord in his temple from the sea (compare Jonah 2:7).

Jonah 2:6

- Jonah's metaphors, like roots of the mountains and the earth beneath me barred me, show ancient ideas about the underworld. People thought the dead were deep within the earth (see also Jonah 2:2). At one point, Jonah felt trapped and doomed to die.
- But: The change is striking. Jonah, though sure he would die, was still within God's gracious reach.
- the pit: The Hebrew term usually refers to the place where the dead are thought to dwell. Jonah's words show that, at this moment, he believed he was about to die.

Jonah 2:7

- I remembered the LORD: Here, Jonah means, "I prayed to the Lord."
- My prayer ... holy temple: The temple was God's special place for worship in Israel, even though God is everywhere all the time (Psalm 139:7–10; Jeremiah 23:23–24).

Jonah 2:8–9

The end of Jonah's psalm-prayer is similar to Jonah 1:16: The sailors also reacted to the Lord's saving power and mercy with sacrifices and promises.

Jonah 3:1–2

The second part of the book begins in the same way as the first part (see Jonah 1:1–2).

Jonah 3:1–4.11

God commands Jonah again to preach to Nineveh. This time, Jonah obeys. Ironically, the city repents, just as Jonah feared, and he becomes angry with God.

Jonah 3:3

- an exceedingly great city, requiring a three-day journey: God wanted to save this vast city, full of people and resources (Jonah 4:11). Jonah opposed God's desire (see Jonah 4:2, 10–11).
- The city was about 4.8 kilometers (3 miles) in distance around it. It would not have taken three days to walk around the city itself. This description likely refers to the time Jonah needed to travel through the city and share his message. It may also include nearby villages along with the main city.

Jonah 3:4

Forty more days and Nineveh will be overturned!: Jonah's message did not seem to include a condition, such as "But if you repent, God will not destroy

you" (note the king's uncertainty in Jonah 3:9). However, Jonah knew God wanted people to repent instead of being destroyed (Jonah 3:10; 4:2).

Jonah 3:5–6

- For the second time in this short book, non-believers respond positively to the Lord (compare Jonah 1:16).
- In ancient Israel, people often fasted during prayer and repentance in difficult times (see 2 Samuel 1:12; Nehemiah 1:4). Wearing burlap and sitting on ashes often showed mourning and deep repentance (see Genesis 37:34; Job 16:15; Lamentations 2:10). The Assyrians had similar customs. These actions allowed people to show their grief in a visible way for everyone, including God, to see.
- The repentance of the Ninevites criticized the stubbornness of people in the time of Jesus (Matthew 12:41).

Jonah 3:6

The king of Nineveh may have been a local ruler who governed the city. It is also possible that he was the king of Assyria, who at times used Nineveh as a center of royal rule (compare 2 Kings 19:9–13).

Jonah 3:7–8

By including animals in fasting and mourning rituals, the king showed the seriousness of the situation. He wanted everyone to stop normal activities to pray and change their bad behavior. Violence was the main problem in their society.

Jonah 3:10

He relented: If the people of Nineveh had not repented, God would have destroyed them (Jonah 3:4). But God was ready to show mercy when they repented (see Jonah 4:2, 11). In God's view, this change did not reverse his original plan, because he always considered the possibility of mercy. This change does not affect God's ability to know the future.

Historically, the church has believed that God fully knows the future (see Psalm 139:4; Isaiah 46:10; Daniel 2:28–29; Matthew 24:36). Nothing in this account contradicts that belief.

Jonah 4:1

however: See study note on Jonah 3:10.

Jonah 4:1–7

The story changes in a surprising way. Jonah, who had received God's mercy himself, complains that the Lord has shown mercy to the Assyrians. The prophet's disrespectful response emphasizes how great God's grace truly is (see Jonah 4:8–11 for God's response).

Jonah 4:2

- Jonah explains why he initially ran away from the Lord (Jonah 1:3): He knew the Lord would spare the wicked Ninevites if they repented.
- I knew: Jonah almost quotes Exodus 34:6–7, which is about Israel's covenant with the Lord. Even in the Old Testament, God wanted to spread salvation to all nations (see Matthew 28:18–20).

Jonah 4:3–5

Jonah's desire to die rather than accept God's will (see also Jonah 4:8–9) and his choice to wait in hope that the city would be destroyed (Jonah 4:5) show his hard heart (his refusal to change or show mercy) and his hatred for the Assyrians.

Jonah 4:4

The Lord responds with a rhetorical question, implying the answer is "No, of course not!" The lesson that follows shows why Jonah should not be angry (Jonah 4:6–11).

Jonah 4:6

- LORD is the English title used in many Bible translations to represent God's covenant name, Yahweh, in his relationship with Israel(see, for example, Psalm 72:18). God did these things to show his covenant love toward Jonah and those in Israel with similar attitudes.
- appointed: see study note on Jonah 1:17.

Jonah 4:11

- who cannot tell their right hand from their left: God sent his message through his prophetic word in a wicked city. Not everyone who encounters God's light responds positively (see John 3:19–21), but God wants to save those who genuinely repent and have faith.
- The book ends suddenly, prompting the reader to consider God's final question to Jonah. God prefers to save rather than destroy. Those who have received his mercy should be happy for that same mercy to be shown to others, even their enemies.